

BP Terms and Phrases

Editor's Note:

The following set of definitions is not meant to serve as an absolute dictionary, nor is it meant to serve as a perfect educational tool. The definitions provided are *colloquial* definitions, meant to help inform new debaters about potentially new or confusing terms they may encounter and provide definitions as to what other debaters/judges *most likely mean* when they use those terms. Many of these terms have other, more traditionally “correct” meanings, and many of these terms have lost popularity over time such that you may never encounter them. It is also important to note that this list has been created primarily from the perspective of the Eastern US Regional circuit, and so although efforts have been made to take into account variations in debate phrases across regions/circuits, this list likely lacks some references to common synonyms/alternative phrases.

If you feel that any of the provided definitions do not speak to a given term's *common colloquial use*, would like to add any synonyms (especially those that are frequently used in other circuits), or would like to add a phrase that is currently missing from this list, please message us at usudaeducation@gmail.com or c.bronte@rochester.edu.

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Motions

- **Motion**

- The “Motion” is the statement that is being debated. In BP debate, the motion almost always begins with the phrase “This House,” which is commonly abbreviated “TH.”
- Similar Phrases: Proposition, Topic, Resolution
- Example Sentence: “The motion about social justice was my favorite to debate.”

- **“This House” or “TH”**

- “This House” refers to the body that is deciding whether or not to support the motion. This means that all teams’ arguments represent a stance that “This House” could take. Whereas some motions limit the scope of “This House” (eg, TH, as X) most motions leave the perspective through which the motion should be examined intentionally vague.
- Example Sentence: “This House prefers debate over model UN”

- **Info Slide**

- An “Info Slide” provides potentially necessary facts or context for the debate prior to or concurrent with the release of the motion. The content of the info slide should be taken as fact during the debate.
- Similar Phrases: Context Slide
- Example Sentence: “The info slide said that Germany has already implemented this policy.”

- **“Analysis” Motions**

- An “Analysis” Motion is a motion that requires debaters to examine whether a neutral body ought to agree with or disagree with a given statement.
- Common Examples: “This House Believes That,” “This House Prefers A over B,” “This House Regrets”
- Example Sentence: “Because the motion was an analysis motion, we didn’t need to argue that the government would intervene.”

- **“Policy” Motions**

- A “Policy” Motion is a motion that requires debaters to examine whether an institutional body ought to implement or not implement a given plan.
- Common Examples: “This House Would,” “This House Should”
- Example Sentence: “Because the motion was a policy motion, we should have explained what a ‘ban’ would entail.”

- **“Actor” Motions**

- An “Actor” Motion is a motion that requires debaters to examine whether a specific actor/group ought to support or not support a given proposal. This is distinct from motions that analyze what a given actor should do from a neutral perspective (eg, “This House Believes That X should”), as these motions explicitly require that the debate should take place from the perspective of the specified actor/group.
- Common Example: “This House, as X, Would”
- Example Sentence: “Because the motion was an actor motion, we needed to more directly question whether this group would agree with our analysis.”

- **“Regrets” Motions**

- A “Regrets” Motion is a type of analysis motion that requires debaters to examine whether or not a past action or perspective was preferable to any other alternative. This is distinct from other analysis motions, as it does not require debaters to analyze how a new idea/action might influence future events, but instead requires debaters to analyze how those alternative ideas/actions might have influenced past and current events.
- Example Sentence: “Because the motion was a regrets motion, we needed to consider a world that never took this action.”

Teams, Speakers, and Team Comparisons

- **Opening Government or “OG”**

- “Opening Government,” most commonly shortened to “OG,” refers to the first team in the round that argues *in support of* the motion.
- Similar Phrases: First Proposition, First Prop, Front-Half Gov, Top-Half Gov
- Less Common Phrases in BP: Affirmative, Aff, First Affirmative, Front-Half Affirmative, Top Half-Affirmative
- Example Sentence: “OG set up a good debate.”

- **Prime Minister or “PM”**

- The “Prime Minister,” most commonly abbreviated to “PM,” is the first speaker of the Opening Government team, and the first speaker in the debate.
- Example Sentence: “The PM didn’t define key terms.”

- **Deputy Prime Minister or “DPM”**

- The “Deputy Prime Minister,” most commonly abbreviated to “DPM,” is the second speaker of the Opening Government team, and the third speaker in the debate.
- Example Sentence: “The DPM did a good job defending the OG case.”

- **Opening Opposition or “OO”**

- “Opening Opposition,” most commonly shortened to “OO,” refers to the first team in the round that argues *against* the motion.
- Similar Phrases: First Opposition, First Opp, Front-Half Opp, Top-Half Opp
- Less Common Phrases in BP: Negative, Neg, First Negative, Front-Half Negative, Top-Half Negative
- Example Sentence: “OO did a good job critiquing both the motion and OG.”

- **Leader of the Opposition or “LO”**

- The “Leader of Opposition,” most commonly abbreviated to “LO,” is the first speaker of the Opening Opposition team, and the second speaker in the debate.
- Similar Phrases: Opposition Leader, Opp Leader
- Example Sentence: “The LO spent too long critiquing the PM’s interpretation of the motion.”

- **Deputy Leader of the Opposition or “DLO”**

- The “Deputy Leader of the Opposition,” most commonly abbreviated to “DLO,” is the second speaker of the Opening Opposition team, and the fourth speaker in the debate.
- Similar Phrases: Opposition Deputy, Opp Deputy
- Example Sentence: “The DLO clarified a lot of what the LO had said.”

- **Closing Government or “CG”**

- “Closing Government,” most commonly shortened to “CG,” refers to the second team in the round that argues *in support of* the motion.
- Similar Phrases: Second Proposition, Second Prop, Back-Half Gov, Bottom-Half Gov
- Less Common Phrases in BP: Affirmative, Aff, Second Affirmative, Back-Half Affirmative, Bottom-Half Affirmative
- Example Sentence: “CG covered a lot of the material OG had missed.”

- **Member of Government**

- The “Member of Government” is the first speaker of the Closing Government team, and the fifth speaker in the debate.
- Similar Phrases: Government Member, Gov Member
- Example Sentence: “The Member of Government didn’t do enough to explain why their case was different from the OG case.”

- **Government Whip**

- The “Government Whip” is the second speaker of the Closing Government team, and the seventh speaker in the debate.
- Example Sentence: “The Gov Whip clearly explained why the CG case was different from the OG case.”

- **Closing Opposition or “CO”**

- “Closing Opposition,” most commonly shortened to “CO,” refers to the second team in the round that argues *against* the motion.
- Similar Phrases: Second Opposition, Second Opp, Back-Half Opp, Bottom-Half Opp
- Less Common Phrases in BP: Negative, Neg, Second Negative, Back-Half Negative, Bottom-Half Negative
- Example Sentence: “CO brought an entirely new perspective to the round.”

- **Member of Opposition**

- The “Member of Opposition” is the first speaker of the Closing Opposition team, and the sixth speaker in the debate.
- Similar Phrases: Opposition Member, Opp Member
- Example Sentence: “The Member of Opposition did a good job explaining why the perspective they took was important to the round.”

- **Opposition Whip**

- The “Opposition Whip” is the second speaker of the Closing Opposition team, and the eight and final speaker in the debate.
- Example Sentence: “The Opp Whip brought up entirely new material that no one had the chance to respond to.”

- **Benches**

- A “Bench” normally refers both to a given side of a debate as well as to the debate that occurs between these teams whether it’s the Government Bench (ie, the Opening Government and Closing Government teams) or the Opposition Bench (ie, the Opening Opposition and Closing Opposition teams).
- Example Sentence: “The opp bench clearly won the round.”

- **The Front-Half (or Top-Half)**

- “Front-Half” or the “Top-Half” refers both to the Opening Government and Opening Opposition teams, as well as to the debate that occurs between these teams.
- Similar Phrases: Opening Teams, Opening Clash
- Example Sentence: “OO won the top-half.”

- **The Back-Half (or Bottom-Half)**

- “Back-Half” or the “Bottom-Half” refers both to the Closing Government and Closing Opposition teams, as well as to the debate that occurs between these teams.
- Similar Phrases: Closing Teams, Closing Clash
- Example Sentence: “CO lost the back-half.”

- **The Long-Diagonal**

- The “Long-Diagonal” refers both to the Opening Government and Closing Opposition teams, as well as to the debate that occurs between these teams.
- Example Sentence: “OG won the long-diagonal.”

- **The Short-Diagonal**

- The “Short-Diagonal” refers both to the Closing Government and Opening Opposition teams, as well as to the debate that occurs between these teams.
- Example Sentence: “CG lost the short-diagonal.”

General BP Debate Terms and Phrases

- **Model**

- A “Model” is a set of definitions provided at the start of the debate, ideally by the prime minister, that clarify any vague terms in the motion and/or detail how specific policies would be implemented.
- Example Sentence: “The PM’s model clearly explained what abolition meant in the context of this round.”

- **Squirrel/Squirrelling**

- A “Squirrel” is any definition which either drastically limits the debate or misrepresents the intended topic of the debate. It is almost always used in reference to definitions provided by a model.
- Example Sentence: “The PM squirrelled the round when they said that the motion about nuclear weapons only applied to France.”

- **The “Heart of the Debate”**

- “The Heart of the Debate” is the intended focus of a given debate. For example, in certain rounds wherein the motion was directly inspired by a specific current event, arguments that speak to the Heart of the Debate would align with any real-world arguments that have developed in response to that current event. In recent years, this term has become less popular, as it is seen as allowing judges to intervene in the debate (ie, judges consider what they would have wanted debaters to say, rather than what was actually said). However, it can be used by debaters to critique the relevance of other team’s cases.
- Example Sentence: “The Opening Government team missed the Heart of the Debate when they failed to acknowledge that this round is clearly about Citizens United.”

- **Extensions**

- “Extensions” are arguments that substantially build on themes and ideas that have already been introduced in the round. They are most commonly used to describe the new arguments or lines of analysis introduced by back-half teams. Extensions can either build on the specific arguments of one’s own top half team, directly respond to the other side’s arguments, or introduce entirely new arguments that are related to whatever side of the motion that team is on.
- Example Sentence: “The Closing Opposition team’s extension was the most persuasive argument in the round.”

- **Extending-In**

- “Extending In” refers to any extension that further analyzes arguments already established by one’s respective top-half team instead of providing entirely new arguments.
- Similar Phrases: Analysis Extensions
- Example Sentence: “The Closing Government team’s attempt to extend-in was really effective, as they managed to take the points already introduced by the Opening Government team and analyze them with much more depth.”

- **Backloading**

- “Backloading” refers to situations wherein the bulk of a given team’s analysis or argumentation isn’t introduced until their second speaker’s speech.
- Example Sentence: “The Opening Opposition team really backloaded their case, so it was impossible for the Opening Government team to directly engage with any of their core arguments.”

- **Whipstensions**

- A “Whipstension” is any entirely new line of analysis that is introduced by a whip speaker. Although it may refer to any material that is substantially new, it is more commonly used to refer to lines of analysis that are significantly more persuasive than the material that was introduced by their partner.
- Example Sentence: “The judges couldn’t consider the Opposition Whip’s whipstension in their adjudication, as it was largely unrelated to their partner’s case and was completely unexpected in the context of the round.”

- **Burnt Turf/Burning Turf**

- “Burning Turf” refers to the act of a top-half team covering as much material as possible so that their respective back-half team has fewer possible opportunities to extend the debate.
- Example Sentence: “The Opening Opposition team really burnt the turf, so we were unsure what arguments to run as Closing Opposition.”

- **Knife/Knifing**

- A “Knife” is any argument that directly contradicts the core arguments that have been made by speakers on one’s own side of the debate. Although it is more common for back-half teams to Knife their front-half team, it is also possible for speakers to Knife their own partner. In BP Debate, judges are instructed to disregard any material that they consider to be a Knife.
- Example Sentence: “We had to disregard a lot of the Closing Government team’s case, as their claim that the media is a fundamentally bad actor clearly knifed Opening Government’s claims that the media is the best actor in this debate.”

- **Points of Information (or “POIs”)**

- A “Point of Information” or “POI” is a brief question or short statement that a debater on the opposite side of the debate from the speaker may offer in order to directly engage during that person’s speech. Speakers have the authority to choose which POIs they would like to accept, but are usually expected to accept at least one per speech. Most tournaments limit POIs to fifteen seconds.
- Example Sentence: “Neither speaker on the Closing Opposition team took any POIs, so it really felt like they were unwilling to engage with the Government teams.”

- **Points of Clarification**

- A “Point of Clarification” is a type of POI that is specifically used to request that a member of the Opening Government team, usually the Prime Minister, further explains some part of their model. There is a heightened expectation that speakers will accept Points of Clarification when they are offered.
- Example Sentence: “Had the Prime Minister accepted any of the Points of Clarification that were offered, they could have avoided a lot of the confusion that arose in the round about how they were defining the motion.”

- **Protected/Unprotected Time**

- “Protected Time” is the period of each speech when debaters are not allowed to offer POIs, whereas “Unprotected Time” is the period of each speech when debaters are allowed to offer POIs. In a standard seven minute speech, Protected Time accounts for the first and last minute of that speech, meaning that POIs can be offered after one minute has passed and can no longer be offered once six minutes have passed. Normally, a judge offers auditory and/or visual signals to indicate to the debaters in the room when POIs are allowed to be offered.
- Example Sentence: “Stop offering POIs, I’m in protected time.”

- **Barracking**
 - “Barracking” usually refers to the act of offering POIs in rapid succession and/or regularly disrupting a speech in order to offer POIs. Most tournaments request that debaters wait at least 15 seconds before offering a POI after they have been rejected by the speaker.
 - Example Sentence: “That speaker has a tendency to barrack other speakers - they just wouldn’t ever sit down.”
- **Spreading**
 - “Spreading” refers to the act of speaking extremely quickly, often too quickly for the average person to understand. Although spreading is popular in other formats of debate wherein the judges have access to written versions of teams’ cases prior to or during the round, it is usually not very effective in BP debate as much of a speaker’s case may be missed or misunderstood.
 - Example Sentence: “In the future, you may want to avoid spreading, as it made it difficult to follow your logic or understand your case.”
- **Signposting**
 - “Signposting” is the act of providing an outline of one’s arguments at the beginning of a speech and then clearly identifying the start of each new argument as one’s speech progresses. It can be a useful tool for communicating the overall logic and organization of a speech.
 - Example Sentence: “The DLO’s speech would have benefitted from signposting, as it was hard to tell when they had moved on to new arguments.”

Arguments and Analysis: Constructive Analysis

- **Constructive Arguments**
 - “Constructive Arguments” are arguments that either contribute entirely new material to the round or substantially build on arguments that had previously been introduced.
 - Similar Phrases: Points of Constructive, Substantive Arguments, Points of Substantive, Offensive Arguments
 - Example Sentence: “I will start my speech by responding to the other teams’ arguments, and then I’ll get into my constructive arguments.”

- **Principled Arguments**

- “Principled Arguments” are any arguments or lines of analysis that heavily rely on value-based logic or ethical appeals.
- Example Sentence: “Our first point of constructive will be a principled argument about the importance of agency.”

- **Practical Arguments**

- “Practical Arguments” are any arguments or lines of analysis that heavily rely on the evaluation of tangible outcomes or quantifiable metrics.
- Example Sentence: “Our second point of constructive will be a practical argument about how this motion would affect low income communities.”

- **Claims**

- “Claims” are any basic arguments or standalone ideas that would need to be supported in order to stand as persuasive or holistic. For example, one may “claim” that the United States should no longer be considered a functional democracy, but would need to analyze that Claim in order for it to be considered a persuasive argument.
- Example Sentence: “Your speech largely consisted of unjustified claims.”

- **Analysis**

- “Analysis” is any explanation that serves to support the logic of an argument.
- Example Sentence: “Our analysis will show that this motion would lessen income inequality.”

- **Warrant**

- A “Warrant” is a point of analysis that serves to explain why a claim is necessarily true or important. Although some warrants can be assumed (eg, it is necessarily true that an increase in taxes would result in an increase in government funds), many warrants need to be verbally explained by debaters (eg, it is necessary to warrant a claim that tax revenue would be allocated to a specific government program, or warrant a claim that that reallocation is net good).
- Example Sentence: “The OO team didn’t warrant any of their claims, and so it’s unclear why we should agree with their arguments.”

- **Impacts**

- “Impacts” are any tangible outcomes or theoretical effects of a given policy, plan, or perspective.
- Example Sentence: “The OG team needed to better explain their impacts, as it was unclear how this motion would actually affect anyone in the real world.”

- **Nuance/Nuanced Analysis**

- “Nuance” or “Nuanced Analysis” is any analysis that is significantly deep, usually because it considers multiple perspectives, multiple actors, or multiple possible outcomes.
- Example Sentence: “The OG case wasn’t very nuanced, as it didn’t consider the political backlash this policy might face.”

- **Actor Analysis**

- “Actor Analysis” is any analysis that directly focuses on how specific people or groups of people would react to or be affected by the motion. Variations of actor analysis may include cases which focus on a singular group by arguing that that group would be the most affected by the implementation of a policy or cases which focus on how the implementation of a policy would impact a variety of different actors.
- Example Sentence: “Our extension will focus on actor analysis by exploring how this motion would impact different groups of people that have been ignored by the opening teams.”

- **Mechanization or “Mechs”**

- “Mechanization,” commonly shortened to “Mechs,” is a form of analysis that explains how a specific action would be implemented and/or why that implementation would generate specific outcomes. Mechanization may include explanations as to how exactly an action or policy would be implemented, what outcomes that implementation would generate, how people would react to specific parts of its implementation, why people would react that way, what the outcomes of those reactions would be, and so on.
- Example Sentence: “The CO team didn’t mechanize their case, and so it was unclear why they believed this policy would lead to widespread corporate bankruptcy.”

- **Fiat**

- “Fiats” are basic assumptions that are usually foundational to either the opening government team’s model, or any team’s policy-based analysis. In BP debate, for example, it *should* be “Fiated” that the motion could in fact be implemented (ie, arguments like “this would never actually happen” are largely irrelevant in BP debate). Other than this central assumption, every other attempt to “Fiat” must be thoroughly justified, as those Fiats could be critiqued (eg, an OG team usually needs to explain why it could be Fiated that a particular round would only involve specific countries, etc).
- Example Sentence: “The gov bench can’t just fiat that the public would support the motion.”

- **Burden**

- A “Burden” is an aspect of a team’s case that they *must* prove in order for their arguments to be considered persuasive. For example, teams that attempt to prove that the implementation of a policy would solve a problem have the “Burden” to explain how that problem would be significantly lessened by the policy. Some Burdens are inherent to a motion, whereas others may be constructed by a given team’s strategic choices.
- Example Sentence: “The opp bench doesn’t have the burden to prove that another perspective is better, they just need to prove why the government perspective is harmful.”

- **Contextualization**

- “Contextualization” refers to any line of analysis that explains how something would look in the real world, or relates a given plan or idea to a specific example or situation.
- Example Sentence: “If the case had better contextualization, it would have been easier to prove that people would actually react the way you claimed they would.”

- **The Status Quo, or “SQUO”**

- The “Status Quo,” sometimes shortened to “SQUO,” refers to the current state of affairs, or the current ways policies and norms operate.
- Example Sentence: “In the status quo, people don’t pay attention to local elections.”

- **Delta**

- A “Delta” is the substantial change to the status quo that would be introduced by a given policy, plan, or perspective.
- Example Sentence: “As Closing Government, we’re going to more closely engage with the Delta by analyzing how this motion would change the status quo.”

- **The Overton Window**

- The “Overton Window” refers to the range of perspectives or policies that would likely be viewed as acceptable within mainstream political or cultural discourse. The Overton Window may refer to either current mainstream ideology, or to possible future mainstream ideologies.
- Example Sentence: “Our second argument will be that this motion will shift the Overton Window such that more people will support the total dissolution of international borders.”

- **Framing**

- “Framing” refers to any definitions, examples, characterizations, or contextualizations that are provided by any debaters in the round, including but not limited to those provided as part of the model. Although framing is not purely argumentative, it may be crucial to the development of any given argument and may become a point of contention in the round if teams disagree on how key definitions or processes ought to be framed.
- Example Sentence: “Every team in this round agreed with OG’s central framing, as no one challenged the idea that this round was about US politics.”

- **Framework**

- “Framework” may refer to either the guiding organization or basic assumptions of a speaker or team’s case.
- Example Sentence: “I want to start my speech by reviewing some crucial framework.”
- “Framework” may also refer to the overall logic of speakers’ or teams’ framing. For example, a team has established a solid “framework” for their ideas when they explain how their case would play out in multiple different situations, or why their logic is still true even in situations where it may not be applied intuitively.
- Example Sentence(s): “The framework of the gov bench was really strong, it was clear that their claims would still stand in a variety of contexts.”

- **Links**

- “Links” are any points of analysis that serve to logically connect separate ideas. For example, a debater might link an action to a given outcome, might link their arguments or examples to the motion, or might link their criticism of another team to one of their arguments.
- Example Sentence: “The PM didn’t link their analysis to the motion, and so it was unclear how this policy actually solves the problems they identified.”

- **Linkwork**

- “Linkwork” refers to the overall logic of speakers’ or teams’ links. For example, good linkwork means that someone’s case was clearly related to the motion, each point was clearly argued from the same general perspective, every example or characterization clearly related to whatever argument it was a part of, etc.
- Example Sentence: “The CG’s linkwork was confusing, it’s unclear how any of their examples support their claims.”

- **Solvency**

- “Solvency” is the effectiveness of any given plan or process. In order for a case to have “solvency,” a debater must clearly explain how specific outcomes are either achieved or avoided.
- Example Sentence: “It’s unclear why the government teams’ cases would have any solvency, as neither team explained why implementing the motion would actually solve the problems they identified.”

Arguments and Analysis: Responsive Analysis

- **Rebuttal**

- “Rebuttal” refers to any sort of argument that directly negates something another team has said or might say.
- Similar Phrases: Points of Rebuttal, Refutation, Points of Refutation, Responses, Defensive Arguments
- Example Sentence: “I’m going to start my speech with two points of rebuttal to the Leader of Opposition’s speech.”

- **Extraneous Rebuttal**

- “Extraneous Rebuttal” refers to any points of rebuttal which are separable from the bulk of a given speaker’s case, usually because they do not directly relate to their own team’s main arguments. Normally, points of extraneous rebuttal occur at the beginning or end of a given debater’s speech.
- Example Sentence: “Before I move onto my two main arguments, I have a few points of extraneous rebuttal.”

- **Interwoven Rebuttal**

- “Interwoven Rebuttal” refers to any points of rebuttal which are not separable from the bulk of a given speaker’s case, usually because they do directly relate to their own team’s main arguments. Normally, interwoven rebuttal appears as analytical references to points other teams have made during one’s own constructive arguments.
- Similar Phrases: Integrated Rebuttal
- Example Sentence: “I want to dive right into my constructive, as all of my responses to the Government teams’ cases will be interwoven.”

- **Countermodel**

- A “Countermodel” is a policy plan that is proposed by the opposition side as a mutually exclusive alternative to the model provided by the government speaker(s).
- Similar Phrases: Counterplan
- Example Sentence: “The LO needed to explain why their countermodel couldn’t happen in the OG world.”

- **Reframing**

- “Reframing” refers to any challenges that are made in response to existing definitions, examples, characterizations, or contextualizations that have already been provided in the round. Reframing is sometimes wrongly conflated with countermodeling when the information that is being reframed was presented as part of the model, but countermodels solely refer to alternative policy plans, not to alternative definitions, perspectives, or contexts.
- Example Sentence: “The CG’s attempt to reframe the round by considering the way countries other than the US would react to the motion was really compelling.”

- **Points of Clash**

- “Points of Clash” are any lines of argumentation that multiple teams in the debate either explicitly or implicitly engaged with. “Points of Clash” can refer to basically anything that was debated, but the *central* “Points of Clash” are the lines of argumentation that were regularly and extensively engaged with by most of the teams in the round.
- Similar Phrases: Points of Crystallization, Points of Contention, Comparatives
- Less Common Phrases in BP: Points of Collapse
- Example Sentence: “The key points of clash in the top half of the debate were about freedom of speech and who better defends the rights of marginalized people.”

- **Flowing**

- “Flowing” refers to the act of taking notes of teams’ arguments and the points of clash that develop during a round, and usually relates to extremely thorough forms of note-taking. The meaning of this phrase is less rigid in BP debate, and is more or less used interchangeably with any note-taking style.
- Example Sentence: “I wasn’t really flowing the round, so it’s hard to tell who won the clash on environmental protections.”

- **The Flow**

- “The Flow” is a holistic representation of teams’ contributions to all of the points of clash in a given round. Again, given that “The Flow” is less important in BP debate because note-taking is less formalized, this phrase is mainly used as a stand in for a largely conceptual perfect record of all points of clash in the round.
- Example Sentence: “The Closing Opposition team really took the flow, as they had sufficient responses to every other team’s main cases.”

- **Weighing**

- “Weighing” is a form of analysis that directly compares the underlying value or overall persuasiveness of multiple different ideas or arguments. For example, if one team has focused on one actor group and another team has focused on a different actor group, speakers on either team might weigh the comparative importance of the actor group they had chosen to focus on. Or, if one team has introduced an entirely different line of argumentation from the other teams in the round, they may weigh why that line of argumentation is more important than what other teams have said.

- Example Sentence: “The Government Whip should have weighed more, as the Closing Government team would have benefitted from more clearly explaining why their arguments were more important than other arguments in the round.
- **Weighing Metric**
 - A “Weighing Metric” is either a commonly agreed upon or analytically supported perspective through which the entire debate ought to be evaluated. For example, utilitarian value is a popular weighing metric, as many teams either explicitly or implicitly argue that they think their side would harm the fewest people.
 - Example Sentence: “We’d like to introduce the protection of marginalized people as the primary weighing metric through which this round ought to be evaluated.”
- **Bright-Line**
 - A “Bright-Line” is a clearly defined standard, weighing metric, or universally harmful impact established by a team or multiple teams’ arguments. In BP debate, it is typically used to criticize a team’s failure to meet their own established standard, but it may be used to criticize any time that a speaker deviates from clearly established definitions or expectations.
 - Example Sentence: “The Opening Government team failed to meet their own Bright-Line when they didn’t explain why this motion increases protections for marginalized people.”
- **Whipping**
 - “Whipping” is a form of comparative analysis that directly explains why one’s own team should rank above another team in the round. Although Whip speakers are best able to do this, as they know the actual arguments every other team ran, the central idea behind whipping (ie, meta-analyzing the round from the perspective of a judge), can be done by most speakers.
 - Example Sentence: “The Government Whip did a good job whipping the round, although they could have better explained why their arguments should have beaten their opening team.”

- **Line-by-Line Rebuttal**

- “Line-by-Line Rebuttal” is a form of rebuttal that provides responses to every argument or assertion that another team or speaker had said, usually in chronological order. Whereas Line-by-Line Rebuttal is much more popular in other formats of debate, it is less popular in BP debate as it may be seen as lessening the depth and quality of a speaker’s responses to other teams or as focusing too heavily on less relevant points.
- Example Sentence: “In the future, you should avoid line-by-line rebuttal and instead pick one or two important points from the other team’s case to respond to.”

- **Turning a Case**

- “Turning a Case” is a form of rebuttal that does not disagree with the bulk of the analysis that has been provided by another team, but instead engages with whether the foundational assumptions, specific links, or overall outcomes of that analysis have been correctly evaluated. For example, “Impact Turns” are traditionally used to describe instances wherein debaters agree that another team’s identified impacts will happen, but disagree on whether those impacts would actually be good or bad. Alternatively, “Link Turns” describe instances wherein debaters agree with foundational analysis, but disagree on whether that analysis would in fact logically lead to a specific set of outcomes, etc.

Judges and Judging

- **Chair Judge**

- The “Chair Judge” is the judge who has been allocated to oversee a given debate round as well as the adjudication of that debate. The Chair Judge is usually responsible for organizing judge and debater introductions at the start of each round, introducing each speaker before their speech, mediating the judge deliberation, breaking ties that might arise during deliberation, delivering the oral adjudication to the debaters, and completing and submitting the ballot.
- Forms of Direct Address: Honorable Chair, Honorable Speaker, Madame Chair, Madame Speaker, Mister Speaker
- Example Sentence: “The Chair will provide each debater the opportunity to introduce themselves and share their pronouns if they want to.”

- **Panelist**

- A “Panelist” is any judge who has been allocated to judge a given round who is not the chair judge. All panelists should play an active part in the judge deliberation.
- Example Sentence: “Other than the Chair, my debate had two panelists.”

- **Trainee Judge**

- A “trainee judge” is usually a type of panelist who has been flagged as requiring more experience judging BP debate. Trainee judges should still play an active part in the judge deliberation and should not be treated any differently from other panelists, but if any given decision during the deliberation requires a vote a trainee judge’s vote should not be counted.
- Example Sentence: “For the first two rounds I was marked as a trainee judge since I’m new to BP debate.”

- **The Panel**

- “The Panel” refers collectively to all of the judges in a given debate, including the chair judge, the panelists, and any trainee judges.
- Example Sentence: “The panel decided that Closing Opposition won the round.”

- **The Floor**

- “The Floor” refers to anyone who watches a speech, and may include other debaters in the round, the judges, or any other observers.
- Example Sentence: “Before I begin, I’d like to address the floor and ask that they refrain from talking during my speech.”

- **The Ballot**

- “The Ballot” is the form through which the judges record teams’ rankings and debaters’ speaker scores for a given debate. Judges may be asked to submit the Ballots in written form, electronically through a tab software, or both.
- Example Sentence: “Some tournaments have judges complete both an electronic and a paper ballot so that it’s easier to check for discrepancies and catch mistakes.”

- **The Deliberation**

- The “Deliberation” is the period of up to 15-20 minutes wherein all judges of a given debate discuss the debate, determine teams’ rankings and debaters’ speaker scores, and complete and submit the ballot.
- Similar Phrases: The Adjudication
- Example Sentence: “The panel spent most of the deliberation discussing the Opening teams because those teams were really close.”

- **The Call**

- The “Call” refers to how teams in a given debate round were ranked by the judges.
- Similar Phrases: The Decision, The Ranking
- Example Sentence: “I’ll start by telling you the call so that you know how you all ranked.”

- **The Reason for Decision or “RFD”**

- The “Reason for Decision,” commonly abbreviated as the “RFD,” refers to the judges’ explanation as to why they arrived at a given ranking.
- Example Sentence: “After telling you the call, I’ll go into the RFD so that you know why we ranked you that way.”

- **The Oral Adjudication**

- The “Oral Adjudication” is the period after the deliberation wherein the judges of a given debate, usually the chair judge specifically, disclose the call to debaters and provide their reason for that decision. Oral Adjudication and RFD are frequently used interchangeably, since most of the Oral Adjudication is spent explaining the RFD.
- Example Sentence: “The deliberation is over, so debaters can come back into the room and hear the oral adjudication.”

- **Open Adjudication**

- “Open Adjudication” refers to any round wherein judges are instructed to deliver an oral adjudication, meaning that debaters are meant to know how they were ranked and why the judges arrived at that decision immediately after the deliberation has ended.
- Example Sentence: “Since this round is Open Adjudication, the debaters should stay by the room so they can hear when the judges call them back in for the oral adjudication.”

- **Closed Adjudication**

- “Closed Adjudication” refers to any round wherein judges are instructed *not* to deliver an oral adjudication, disclose the call, or provide a reason for decision, meaning that debaters are not permitted to know how they were ranked or why the judges arrived at that decision until a later period of the tournament.
- Example Sentence: “Since this round is Closed Adjudication, debaters shouldn’t return to the room after the debate is over and will need to reach out to the judges directly after the break if they want to know more about how they were ranked.”

- **Split Decision**

- “Split Decisions” are decisions that required a vote, meaning that judges could not agree on a consensus decision. The judge delivering the oral adjudication will usually explain the basic dynamics of that split.
- Example Sentence: This round was a 2-1 split decision, meaning that two judges voted in favor of the call and one voted against it.

- **Rolling the Chair**

- “Rolling the Chair” refers to a split decision wherein the chair judge was outvoted by the other members of the panel. When a chair is “rolled,” some tournaments require that another member of the panel delivers the oral adjudication, however it is usually up to the chair’s discretion whether they deliver the oral adjudication in this situation or not.
- Example Sentence: “Since I was rolled on this call, one of the panelists in the majority will be delivering that part of the oral adjudication since they can better explain their own perspective.”

- **Judge Paradigm**

- A “Judge Paradigm” may refer to a specific judges’ procedural model or philosophical perspective through which they adjudicate the round. In BP debate, the use of this phrase is rare, as judges are meant to attempt to be as neutral as possible in their paradigmatic evaluation of a round.
- Example Sentence: “Some judge paradigms are more critical of Opening Government teams that fail to model the round.”

Speaker/Team Statuses and Designations

- **Unaffiliated Speaker/Team**

- A speaker may be designated as “unaffiliated” if they are not participating as a direct representative of a specific academic institution. If both speakers in a given debate partnership are unaffiliated, then the team is designated as an unaffiliated team. This status is primarily relevant for registration purposes, as some tournaments do not allow unaffiliated speakers or teams.
- Example Sentence: “My partner and I registered as unaffiliated since we have both graduated.”

- **Hybrid Team**

- A “Hybrid Team” is any debate partnership that consists of two speakers who are not participating as representatives of the same academic institution. This may include teams that consist of debaters from two different academic institutions or teams where one debater is directly affiliated with an academic institution and the other is not. This status is primarily relevant for registration purposes, as some tournaments may not allow hybrid teams, especially when one or both speakers are not affiliated with an academic institution. In other forms of debate, the phrases “hybrid teams” and “swing teams” are sometimes used interchangeably.
- Example Sentence: “Since my partner and I are from different universities, we’re registered as a hybrid team.”

- **Swing Team**

- A “Swing Team” is a team that debates in order to ensure that the total number of teams participating in the tournament is divisible by four. They may be allocated in the draw itself, or may be called to fill in for teams after the draw has already been announced. Swing teams may consist of only one person, may not consist of the same speaker or speakers every round, and may not be bound by the same eligibility requirements as other debaters in the round (ie, may be unaffiliated, may represent the academic institution hosting the tournament). Due to these characteristics, Swing Teams are normally not eligible to break, even if their participation has been consistent.
- Example Sentence: “We need to call in a swing team because one of the teams didn’t show up.”

- **Iron Person**

- An “Iron Person” is a speaker who participates in a given round without a partner, meaning that they deliver both speeches. Most tournaments do not allow speakers to register as an Iron Person, designate how many rounds a speaker can debate without their partner before they are no longer eligible to break, and have specific policies on how an Iron Person’s speaker score from that round will be tabulated.
- Similar Phrases: Maverick, Iron Man, Iron Woman
- Example Sentence: “I need to Iron Person this round because my partner is too sick to debate.”

- **English as a Foreign Language (EFL) Speaker/Team**

- An “English as a Foreign Language”/“EFL” speaker is any debater who does not regularly use English in their day-to-day life and/or is far more proficient in an alternative language. When *both* speakers in a given debate partnership qualify for EFL status, the team may be designated as an EFL team.
- Important Note: Tournaments which designate EFL status will usually release specific metrics to further define whether speakers might qualify for this language status or not.
- Similar Designations: Spanish as a Foreign Language (for Spanish language tournaments)
- Example Sentence: “My partner and I are designated EFL because we’re still learning English.”

- **English as a Second Language (ESL) Speakers/Teams**

- An “English as a Second Language”/“ESL” speaker is any debater who, although they may be reasonably proficient in English and may use it regularly in their day-to-day life, is still significantly more proficient in an alternative language. When either *both* speakers in a given debate partnership qualify for ESL status, or one speaker qualifies for EFL status and the other qualifies for ESL status, the team may be designated as an ESL team.
- Exclusivity: ESL status is non-exclusive to EFL status, meaning that EFL speakers may qualify for ESL speaker awards and EFL teams may qualify for ESL elimination rounds.
- Important Note: Tournaments which designate ESL status will usually release specific metrics to further define whether speakers might qualify for this language status or not.
- Similar Designations: Spanish as a Second Language (for Spanish language tournaments)

- Example Sentence: “My partner and I are designated ESL because we’re not nearly as comfortable speaking in English as we are speaking in our first language.”

- **English as a Primary Language (EPL) Speakers/Teams**

- An “English as a Primary Language”/“EPL” speaker is any debater who uses English in their day-to-day life and is similarly proficient in English as they may be in any other primary language, even if English is not technically their “first” language. When *at least one* speaker in a given debate partnership qualifies for EPL status, the team may be recognized as an EPL team.
- Exclusivity: Given that EPL status is usually not formally designated (ie, there are not EPL speaker awards/elimination rounds), “EPL” is mainly used as a catch-all signification for speakers or teams that would not qualify for EFL or ESL status.
- Important Note: Tournaments which designate EFL or ESL status will usually release specific metrics to further define whether speakers might qualify for EPL language status or not.
- Similar Designations: Spanish as a Primary Language (for Spanish language tournaments)
- Example Sentence: “As someone who has regularly spoken English my entire life, I’m an EPL speaker.”

- **Rookie Speakers/Teams**

- A “Rookie” speaker is any debater who is in their first year of debate, including participation in debate formats other than BP debate as well as in high school/pre-collegiate debate formats. When *both* speakers in a given debate partnership qualify for Rookie status, the team may be designated as a Rookie team.
- Important Note: Tournaments which designate Rookie status will usually release specific metrics to further define whether speakers might qualify for this status or not.
- Example Sentence: “I qualify as a rookie speaker because I’ve never done debate before this semester.”

- **Novice Speakers/Teams**

- A “Novice” speaker is any debater who is in their first year of collegiate debate, not including high school/pre-collegiate experience. When *both* speakers in a given debate partnership qualify for Novice status, or when one speaker qualifies for Rookie status and the other qualifies for Novice status, the team may be designated as a Novice team.
- Exclusivity: Novice status is non-exclusive to Rookie status, meaning that Rookie speakers may qualify for Novice speaker awards and Rookie teams may qualify for Novice elimination rounds.
- Important Note: Tournaments which designate Novice status will usually release specific metrics to further define whether speakers might qualify for this status or not.
- Example Sentence: “I qualify as a novice speaker because this is my first year doing college debate.”

- **Open Speakers/Teams**

- An “Open” speaker is any debater who does not qualify for Novice or Rookie status, meaning that they have participated in collegiate debate for more than a year. When *at least one* speaker in a given debate partnership qualifies for Open status, the team may be designated as an Open team.
- Exclusivity: This designation is non-exclusive, meaning that debaters that are not designated as Open speakers may still qualify for Open speaker awards, and debate partnerships that are not designated as Open teams may still qualify for Open elimination rounds.
- Similar Phrases: Varsity Speakers/Teams
- Example Sentence: “I’m an open speaker because I’ve been doing college debate for more than a year.”

Tournament Officials

- **The Chief Adjudication Team (or the “CA” Team)**

- Basic Definition: The Chief Adjudication team is responsible for writing motions, delivering debater and judge briefings, allocating judges, and reviewing judge feedback. Importantly, the members of the CA team (Chief Adjudicators/CAs) are the only debate tournament participants that may answer questions about the motion.
- Similar Phrases: The Adjudication Core, the Adj Core
- Example Sentence: “The CAs set really cool motions at this tournament.”

- **Equity Officers**

- “Equity Officers” are a team of people who work to construct and implement a tournament’s equity policy, mediate conflicts that arise during the duration of the tournament, disseminate information about equity-related practices and issues, and direct participants to relevant institutional resources. In some cases, Equity Officers may also work directly with members of the CA team in order to review the language of debate motions, ensure equitable judge allocation, or otherwise help foresee possible equity-related problems.
- Example Sentence: “I need to speak to an equity officer because I need help responding to the offensive comments another debater in my last round made.”

- **The Tab Team**

- “The Tab Team” is the group of people who collect ballots from judges, organize registration information, input tab information or oversee the collection of tab information during the tournament (if it is inputted through tabbing software), and release tab information at the completion of the tournament. Members of the Tab Team may also be responsible for collecting registration information, manually allocating teams (if tabbing software is not used), or assisting the CA team with judge allocation (especially when judge feedback is collected through tabbing software).
- Example Sentence: “I need to get my ballot to the tab so they can run the draw for the next round on time.”

- **Runners**

- “Runners” are the group of people who assist the tab team in collecting ballots, especially at tournaments that use written ballots. Runners may also ensure that given debates and judge deliberations end on time, that participants are able to locate the rooms, or that swing teams are contacted when they are needed.
- Example Sentence: “Is there a runner to take my ballot to tab?”

- **Tournament Organizer(s)**

- The “Tournament Organizer” or “Tournament Organizers” are responsible for preparing for and implementing the tournament. This usually includes selecting a Chief Adjudicator (or the entire CA team), the Equity Team, and the Tab Team, overseeing any volunteers (including runners), collecting registration information and fees, and organizing any other facets of the tournament that are not the direct responsibility of any other tournament officials.
- Similar Phrases: Tournament Host(s), Tournament Director(s)
- Example Sentence: “I’ll contact the tournament organizer to see if they have a strict registration deadline.”

- **Organizing Committee (or “Org Com”)**

- The “Organizing Committee” refers collectively to every individual who is responsible for the direct implementation of some aspect of the tournament, meaning that it includes the Tournament Organizers, the CA team, the Equity Team, the Tab Team, and any volunteers that hold leadership positions.
- Example Sentence: “The Org Com for that tournament ran everything perfectly, the rounds were all on schedule, the motions were great, and the food was even good.”

Types of Tournaments

- **Intervarsity Tournaments (or “IVs”)**

- In BP debate, an “Intervarsity Tournament” or an “IV” colloquially refers to any tournament that limits participation to speakers who are currently pursuing a post-secondary degree (eg, enrolled in college, graduate school, etc.). This usually means that unaffiliated speakers/teams are not permitted to participate, and hybrid teams may need to prove their individual academic affiliations.
- Similar Phrases: Closed Tournaments, Intercollegiate Tournaments, Invitational Tournament
- Important Note: Technically, “Intervarsity” or “IV” is meant to refer to any tournament that does not separate participants into divisions during pre-elimination rounds. Some tournaments that are open to unaffiliated speakers/teams do still refer to themselves as “Intervarsity Tournaments” or have “Intervarsity Divisions” for this reason. However, given that most BP debate tournaments do not separate participants into divisions during pre-elimination rounds and the majority of tournaments require that debaters are actively pursuing post-secondary degrees, the term has largely grown to refer to both tournament structures.
- Example Sentence: “This is my last year to go to the Greendale IV before I graduate.”

- **Open Tournaments**

- An “Open Tournament” is any tournament that does not limit participation based on academic status or affiliation. This means that debaters are eligible to participate even if they have not yet pursued a post-secondary degree, have already completed their higher education, or are not currently enrolled in a college/university.
- Example Sentence: “Even though they graduated last year, I want to ask my former partner to debate with me at the Greendale Open.”

- **Round Robins**

- A “Round Robin” tournament is any tournament with a small enough number of participants that each team usually debates against every other team at least once. In many cases, registration for Round Robins is itself competitive, meaning that teams need to qualify, be invited, or apply to participate.
- Example Sentence: “Sure there are only sixteen teams, but I know everyone at the Greendale Round Robin!”

- **Scrimmages**

- A “Scrimmage” is a smaller tournament that usually consists of teams from nearby schools or schools that have been directly invited to participate. Scrimmages are far less likely than other types of tournaments to be traditionally competitive, meaning that they sometimes do not have elimination rounds.
- Example Sentence: “The Greendale/City College scrimmage will be a fun opportunity to debate with people from another school” (or, alternatively, “The Greendale/City College scrimmage was a really disappointing television portrayal of collegiate debate.”)

- **Masters’ Tournaments**

- A “Masters’ Tournament” is a small tournament that typically runs either immediately before, during, or after a much larger tournament and is open to any of that other tournament’s participants, including speakers, judges, coaches, and observers. In many cases, Masters’ Tournament have their own set of unique debating rules and expectations. For example, WUDC’s Masters’ Tournament includes comedy as a judging metric.
- Example Sentence: “I saw that judge in the Masters’ Tournament the other day, I hope they’re a better judge than they are a comedian.”

Tournament Structures and Metrics

- **The Draw**

- “The Draw” refers to the public announcement of all participants’ room assignments, teams’ position allocations, and judges’ allocations.
- Example Sentence: “Most tournaments project the draw in an auditorium so everyone can see what room they’re supposed to go to and what position they’re in, but tab softwares like Tabbycat also make it available online.”

- **Prep Time**

- “Prep Time” is the period of approximately 15 minutes between the release of the motion and the start of the debate when debaters are able to strategize and brainstorm arguments with their partner.
- Example Sentence: “Some debaters like to spend the first few minutes of prep time thinking about the motion independently, whereas others spend the whole time talking to their partner.”

- **Pre-Elimination Rounds**

- “Pre-Elimination Rounds” are any rounds that are open to all tournament participants. Tournaments usually have between four and nine Pre-Elimination Rounds, the exact number of which depends on the size and duration of the tournament.
- Similar Phrases: In-Rounds, Preliminary Rounds, Prelims
- Example Sentence: “If you do well enough in the pre-elimination rounds, you’ll qualify to compete in the elimination rounds.”

- **Elimination Rounds**

- “Elimination Rounds” are any rounds that are only open to the tournament participants who qualified for them. Elimination Rounds usually include at least an Open Semifinal and Open Final Round, but may also include Open Quarterfinals/Octofinals/Double-Partial Octofinals or Novice/ESL/EFL Quarterfinals/Semifinals/Finals (depending on Novice/ESL/EFL participation).
- Similar Phrases: Out-Rounds, Final Rounds, Break Rounds
- Example Sentence: “Since we were the top-ranked team in the pre-elimination rounds, we knew we’d qualify for the elimination rounds.”

- **Team Points**

- “Team Points” refer to the points that are acquired by debate partnerships during the pre-elimination rounds. Ranking first place in a round gets a team three team points, ranking second place gets two team points, ranking third place gets one team point, and fourth place gets no team points. Total team points are the primary metric used to determine which teams advance to elimination rounds.
- Example Sentence: “My partner and I had nine team points after the fourth round, so we’re doing really well.”

- **“Got the One” (“Two”/“Three”/“Four”)**

- When a speaker says the “Got the One,” they are most likely referring to their team rank for a given round. Speakers who “Got the One” ranked first place, speakers who “Got the Two” ranked second place, speakers who “Got the Three” ranked third place, and speakers who “Got the Four” ranked fourth place. This phrase is commonly misused such that team rank is confused with team points (ie, saying “we got the three” to mean “we ranked first place”).
- Similar Phrases: Took the One/etc., Got the L (meaning “lost the round”), Took the L
- Example Sentence: “We got the four last round, so we need to get the two or higher next round to stay on track to break.”

- **Speaker Scores**

- “Speaker Scores,” commonly shortened to “speaks,” refer to the scores that are awarded to individual debaters during pre-elimination rounds. Speaker Scores are assigned by the discretion of the judges, although the combined Speaker Scores of both debaters in a given team must correlate with that team’s rank in the round. Average Speaker Scores are the metric used to determine which debates win speaker awards, and aggregated Speaker Scores are the secondary metric used to determine which teams advance to elimination rounds when team points are tied.
- Similar Phrases: Speaker Points
- Example Sentence: “When the tab was released I found out that my speaks for that round we won were really great - I got an 82!”

- **Overall Team Rank or Team Seed**

- An “Overall Team Rank” refers to any given team’s standing during the pre-elimination rounds compared to every other team’s combined team points and aggregated speaker scores. Team Ranks are the exact metric used to determine which teams advance to elimination rounds, and are also the metric used to determine which room teams are placed in if the division they qualify for breaks to at least semifinals.
- Similar Phrases: Team Seed, Team Standing
- Example Sentence: “After the fifth round we were the third seed team, but since we got the four in the sixth round we fell in the team ranks.”

- **The Tab**

- “The Tab” is the record of the results of each round, including but not limited to teams’ rankings, team’s accumulated team points, team’s aggregated speaker scores, and debaters’ average speaker scores. Prior to the completion of the tournament, most of the tab is hidden from the public.
- Example Sentence: “I hope they release the tab soon, I want to know if my average speaks at this tournament were better than they were last year.”

- **Speaker Scale**

- A “Speaker Scale” is a set of guidelines disseminated by tournament officials in order to standardize the assignment of speaker scores throughout the tournament. Notable examples include the most recent WUDC Speaker Scale and EUDC Speaker Scale.
- Example Sentence: “Since judges have started expanding the range of speaker scores they’re willing to give, it’s even more important that tournaments use speaker scales to define a standard for what sort of speech qualifies for an 85.”

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- **Divisions**

- A “division” refers to a separated subset of a given tournament wherein debaters are only eligible to participate based on specific designations such as their novice status or language status. Pre-elimination divisions are somewhat rare in BP debate, as most tournaments do not separate teams based on their designations until elimination rounds. Notable examples of this include Novice Championships or Language-Specific tournaments (such as tournaments with Spanish-language Divisions).
- Example Sentence: “At this tournament, if a team qualifies for both the novice and open division breaks, they can choose which elimination round they’d rather participate in.”

- **The Break**

- “The Break” is the period of the tournament when only the highest placed teams in any given division advance to compete in elimination rounds. There is usually a public break announcement that may or may not happen at the same time as the tournament’s award ceremony.
- Example Sentence: “The break will be announced immediately following the completion of the sixth round.”

- **To Break**

- “Breaking” refers to qualifying for a given elimination round. For example, a team has “broken novice” if they have qualified for novice elimination rounds, or is on track “to break open” if they currently have enough points to qualify for the open elimination rounds.
- Example Sentence: “Since we’re doing really well so far, I think we might be able to break at this tournament.”

- **To Drop**

- “Dropping” refers to failing to qualify for a subsequent elimination round after the break. For example, a team might “drop” after the quarterfinal round.
- Example Sentence: “We dropped after the semis because we ran a pretty risky case that didn’t work out.”

- **Breaking To**

- “Breaking To” is used to describe which elimination round will occur first any given division. For example, a tournament is “Breaking To” EFL quarterfinals if the first elimination round in the EFL division is a quarterfinal round.
- Example Sentence: “Since this tournament had more novice teams than we expected, we’ve decided to break to novice semifinals.”

- **Finals**

- “Finals” are the last elimination round of any given division. In BP Debate, Final Rounds consist of four teams competing in one debate, after which one team is selected as the winner.
- Example Sentence: “The debaters in the finals were some of the best I’ve ever seen.”

- **Semifinals or “Semis”**

- “Semifinals” are the second to last possible elimination round of any given division. In BP Debate, Semifinal Rounds consist of eight teams competing in two separate debates, after which two teams from each debate are selected to advance to that division’s final round.
- Example Sentence: “I can’t decide which semifinal I want to watch - should we flip a coin?”

- **Quarterfinals or “Quarters”**

- “Quarterfinals” are the third to last possible elimination round of any given division. In BP Debate, Quarterfinal Rounds consist of sixteen teams competing in four separate debates, after which two teams from each debate are selected to advance to that division’s semifinal round.
- Example Sentence: “Since sixteen teams compete, tournaments with fewer than thirty teams usually don’t break to quarters.”

- **Octofinals or “Octos”**

- “Octofinals” are the fourth to last possible elimination round of any given division at an especially large tournament. In BP Debate, Octofinal Rounds consist of thirty-two teams competing in eight separate debates, after which two teams from each debate are selected to advance to that division’s quarterfinal round.
- Example Sentence: “Since thirty-two teams compete, only really big tournaments like nationals break to octos.”

- **Partial-Double Octofinals or “PDOs”**

- “Partial-Double Octofinals” are sometimes the fifth to last possible elimination round. When a tournament breaks to Partial-Double Octofinals, forty-eight teams break. The top sixteen teams immediately advance to that division’s octofinal round. The remaining thirty-two teams (the teams ranked seventeenth through forty-eighth) compete in eight separate debates, after which two teams from each of those debates are selected to advance to compete against the teams that immediately advanced to that division’s octofinal round. Partial-Double Octofinals are exceptionally rare, and are usually only encountered at extremely large tournaments like WUDC. Additionally, some recent tournaments have started running Partial-Double Quarterfinals that operate in a similar way.
- Example Sentence: “Since we were the tenth breaking team, we can sleep through PDOs.”

- **Power Matching**

- “Power Matching” refers to a style of draw allocation wherein teams with similar team points are slotted to compete against one another. For example, teams that have accumulated five team points will most likely be allocated to debate rooms with other teams that also have five team points.
- Important Note: In BP Debate, Power Matching is only based on team rankings at that specific tournament, as records do not carry across tournaments.
- Similar Phrases: Power Pairing, Ranked Allocation, Ranked Matching, Ranked Pairing
- Example Sentence: “Even though the tournament doesn’t have separate novice and open divisions, by the third or fourth round we should be power matched with debaters who are our skill level.”

- **Pull Ups/Pull Downs**

- In a power matched draw allocation, “Pull Ups” and “Pull Downs” refer to teams that are not slotted to compete against teams that have equivalent team points. “Pull Up” teams are slotted to compete against teams with a higher number of team points, and “Pull Down” teams are slotted to compete against teams with a lower number of team points. In some cases, teams are allocated as Pull Ups/Pull Downs based on their total number of aggregated speaker points (for example, the team on five points that is selected to compete with teams on six points is selected because they had the highest number of aggregated speaker points of any five point team).
- Example Sentence: “After talking to some of the other teams in our room, we realized we were a pull up team - every other team went into that round on eight points and we only had seven.”

- **Straights/On Straights**

- “Straights” is the number of team points a team would need to acquire at a tournament in order to have accumulated an average of two team points per round. A team is “On Straights” if, after any given round, the number of points they have accumulated so far is equal to the number of rounds they have participated in times two. For example, “Straights” at the end of a five round tournament is ten points, and a team in “On Straights” if, after the third round of that tournament, they have six points. In many cases, this is used to predict whether a team is on track to qualify for the open break, as the cutoff number of team points necessary to break open at most tournaments is usually close to “Straights.”
- Example Sentence: “Since we have 8 points after the fourth round, we’re on straights.”

- **Plus One (and Plus Two/Plus Three/etc.)**

- A team is “Plus One” if they have one more point than would be needed to be “On Straights.” For example, given that Straights after four rounds is eight team points, if a team has nine team points then they are Plus One, if they have ten team points then they are Plus Two, etc.
- Example Sentence: “Since we have 7 points after the third round, we’re on plus one.”

- **Minus One (and Minus Two/Minus Three/etc.)**

- A Team is “Minus One” if they have one less point than would be needed to be “On Straights.” For example, given that Straights after four rounds is eight team

points, if a team has seven team points then they are Minus One, if they have six team points then they are Minus Two, etc.

- Example Sentence: “Since we have five points after the third round, we’re on minus one.”